We're In The After Now (First Nights Part II)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/31211906.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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by JazzKat1213

Summary

It's day three after defeating Prime. Etheria is at peace, finally. And so are they; they've said I love you, they're *happy*. They're ready to start trying to *believe* rather than simply just *know* what they are to each each now. Which may or may not be easier given that they're going to have to explain the Heart to their friends.

Part I

Chapter Notes

> This follows on directly from the end of First Nights. (They have had the night after Prime's defeat and two days after.) It will probably be able to stand alone but some things won't make sense.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora

She's had so many dreams exactly like this one.

Brightmoon. Her room. Catra in her bed.
Pure longing.

Usually there's pale golden light flooding in from the arch windows blurring the details. This is dark from drawn curtains, the colours not faded. Usually Catra is lying next to her, silent and asleep the way she never really was. Sometimes she's looking at her, wide-eyed and curious like she's surprised she's there too. Sometimes she even speaks, words floaty and ethereal because even her subconscious knows the only way she'd ever have Catra in her Brightmoon bed is for it to be a dream.

Sometimes...sometimes Catra kisses her, she knows that's what happens even though any feeling is absent. It's always a mercy that she doesn't know what it feels like in actuality. She can never feel Catra, even when they appear to touch; just a memory of how warm she is.
This - this isn't like that. This is *heat*.
Pressed lightly against her side, against her hand, her abdomen, behind her head.

She stares at the ceiling. Sinking into the feeling without questioning why it's there. Oh so carefully looking at everything but the other person in the bed, she's surprised her mind is letting her. It's always made her look before, see what she wants more than anything. Seeing Catra will make this sting like a wound when she wakes up. *If* she wakes up. For all she knows this dream might not end. She's been threatened with it more than once, maybe this time the bad guy has won. She can't bring herself to feel scared of that right now.

Because Catra's with her. Catra's wrapped around her, kind of. The arm she feels behind her head is - it's real. It has to be. Dreams, holograms, wishes made of viruses don't *feel* like this. They shatter before she can be truly *happy* within them.

And she looks. Because somehow, *somehow* it's safe to now, somewhere she knows this. Catra's asleep beside her, snoring in the quiet, snuffling way she's always done. No wrong silence. And she's close, close enough she can hear Catra's breaths, can see the movement in her chest.

Adora freezes.
Firstly because Catra is here. Their tangled hands on her stomach, all of it, is real. Her other arm is still in the position it was when she fell asleep, half pressed up against Catra's chest, and her fingers curled under Catra's chin.
Secondly, because Catra's always been a light sleeper. Unsurprising considering how they grew up...and everything since.

So she looks. Because she's awake and touching Catra and she's not fading. And she remembers everything. The *I love you*s, the - the *kissing*, most of all. She carefully pulls her curled arm away, just so she won't accidentally wake Catra by scratching under her chin, and lays it higher over her own chest.

She spent the smallest part of yesterday morning looking at Catra's freckles from this close. She's always adored them, she always will. One day she'll have kissed every one of them and it

makes her ridiculously giddy to realise. And so maybe she's smiling stupidly at a sleeping woman, why would she care when she's this happy?

She gets to kiss her today. After last night, she's sure of it. They're - they are *together* now. Whether Catra wants to say they're *girlfriends* remains to be seen but if she said no...Adora wouldn't care. They are more than they were, they are what she's always deep down wanted them to be. Whatever label Catra wants them to have, or not have, she'll accept gladly.

She kind of wants Catra to wake up right now so she can tell her she loves her. But just like before, she would never take from Catra what precious sleep she can find. Even if it is to tell her their no-longer-a secret. Gods, she's still thrilling over it days later. The relief hasn't left either. There is still...pretty much everything she was feeling that first night together. Less shock though; it's settling in now, slowly.

She thinks about looking away when Catra finally rouses but...she didn't yesterday and Catra just smiled. She doesn't have to pretend anymore. She's still getting used to Catra waking up slowly - the way her face scrunches up before smoothing out into a miniscule smile, instead of her grumbling and burying back under covers. Not that that behavior was allowed in the Horde, but she knows Catra wanted to.

Catra blinks at her slowly, voice rough with sleep, "Hey Adora." She doesn't even look like she knows she's already purring.

Adora's grinning so wide it hurts and she thinks Catra's going to roll her eyes and tuck into her arm to escape it but she doesn't. Maybe Catra was so bad in the mornings because she was forced to be awake. She's almost awestruck in knowing she'll have enough time to figure it out.

"Hey Catra."
There's the eyeroll, however small it is. She feels Catra's muscles flex under her head, "Mind giving me my arm back? It's dead."

She lifts up just enough for the limb to be removed before she's sinking back down. Catra looks down at their joined hands, the ear that's not trapped under her head sloping softly. Adora wants to pet her again, like she did the other day. She *knows* how soft her ears and hair are now.

But she doesn't want to move, and Catra's purring anyway, playing with their twined fingers.
"Do you want to talk?" she asks even though she would be perfectly content to stay in this moment for the rest of forever.
Catra sounds nervous when she whispers, "Not yet. I'm...I want to stay like this."
"Me too." She means it. She'll take however much of this Catra will let her have today.

She lets herself breathe the moment in, only sensations coming from the sound Catra's making and the feeling of her hand in hers. And even though she's looking at Catra, and Catra looks at her too, for the first time in her life she almost falls back to sleep in the morning. But Catra takes her hand away and she forces herself to open her eyes fully.

"You can go back to sleep if you want."
"Don't want to sleep. I want to spend time with you." And Catra purrs louder.

Catra sits up slowly, rubbing at her eyes. It pulls the covers down when she moves, the purple sheets pooling around her waist. Adora just watches as Catra looks around, her purr fading out. There's something telling her to sit up too, to wrap her arms around her waist and trail kisses along her shoulders. She's sure it's the first fantasy she's had that hasn't been burdened by guilt, the freedom of it, of knowing she *could* is near blinding.

So she stays still, lying on her back and waiting, meeting Catra's eyes easily when she half-turns over her shoulder to look at her.
"So...I'm in Brightmoon."
"Yeah," it's so entirely breathless and she doesn't care at all.
"...You think it's terrible, huh?"

Catra's tail lays over her thigh under the covers. "This room? It's okay."

It's probably obvious how happy that makes her - it feels like Catra's accepting her as strange as that is. Catra settles down on her right arm, taking a moment to...collect herself? Adora doesn't know. Catra just looks down at her and whispers, "I'll get used to it."
And it just...it *keeps* her breathless because it means Catra wants to be in her room long enough *to* get used to it.

Catra bites her lip before she reaches out, there's hesitancy in the movement and Adora gets it. She makes sure to lean into the touch as Catra brushes her hair behind her ear. Catra notices. Of course she does. And she tangles her hand in her hair fully.
Catra just holds her, looks at her like she's so much more than she is. It's a *look* of all things but it's just so...unlike the Catra she knows that she can't really think. It's gentle. Just entirely delicate and calm and unmoving.

It's hard to grasp that this is the same woman who wanted to burn the world down and yet her heart is so full seeing it. It makes *sense* to have it here. There were glimpses of this when they were younger; a softer Catra who hadn't yet learned of how hurt she'd be. Or maybe that's not it at all. Maybe that was just a Catra who was still *letting* herself care. Letting herself love.
She now knows Catra always *did*. She said always. She *meant* always.

She is letting Adora see this. And everything...just feels so right. Two days isn't enough for her to convince herself Catra loves her. She *knows*, but believing is different. However, believing is a whole lot easier with Catra *gazing* at her in her bed in the morning.
Maybe that's why she says; "You love me."

Catra's not expecting it. And it is nice taking her by surprise, even if the look breaks. Catra seems like she wants to shy away but she *doesn't*.

"...Yeah - yeah I do."
She might be embarrassed of the delighted sound she makes but Catra relaxes just a little more, and then she's dragging Catra closer with a hand on the back of her neck. She stops before she actually kisses her, but she's not being subtle about what she wants to do. Her chest feels like it's bursting.
"I love you. I love you so mu-"
Catra cuts her off and it doesn't matter.

Her previously calm heart rate skyrockets, as does Catra's, she can feel her pulse under her hand. Catra leans into it more just as she recognises the newer scar tissue under her palm. She is dizzy and in desperate need of air from the kiss, from the words, from her feelings, but that's not why she pulls back.
"Wait is this okay?" She squeezes the hand on the back of Catra's neck so she understands. And she does, face softening a little.
"Yeah. Means the chip's not there."
"Okay, okay, right." She would not go as far as to say she's dazed, but she's not exactly far off from it either.

Catra chuckles quietly at her and she wants to kiss her again *so badly* but it still feels like she needs some sort of permission for it.
"Catra?"
Catra shifts closer, still propped up on her arm with her hand in her hair, "Hm?"
"Can you…?"
She sees the sheets moving from the wave of Catra's tail under them, she can tell Catra's excited or something similar from that alone. She doesn't really need the remarkably open expression on her face. "Can I what?"

She probably shouldn't need to *steel* herself for this - Catra's *not* going to reject her. She's still slow in bringing them back together. She's still nervous even though Catra near trills under her hands the way she hasn't done since she was a kitten.

"Never feel bad about asking if you can kiss me."
"I'll try."
Catra knows what that means.

She can’t help giggling when Catra purrs, the vibrations of it making her lips tingle. It feels amazing, though she’s maybe influenced by her own joy. She knows there’s more to kissing than the closed lip connections they’ve only done so far. She wonders what Catra’s purr is going to feel like when they do that. (And she’s pretty sure it is *when* not if.)

After she breaks their kiss to laugh for a second time, Catra nips at her jaw. It shuts her up pretty efficiently. Which makes Catra snort in the way she’s always been a little self-conscious of. Catra tells her, “Anymore than that is gonna taste disgusting,” when she’s stopped snickering. And she may be right, but it’s not going to stop her pouting.

Catra moves away and on top of her, the distance between them reliant on her arms. Adora’s not sure what she’s more distracted by; Catra above her, sitting on her thighs, or the truly smug grin she’s wearing.
“You really wanna kiss me that bad?”

She takes a risk now - well, not exactly a risk. The most that’ll happen is that Catra might growl or just get off her. She can deal with either outcome. It’s been far too long since she’s teased Catra in any respect. Plus, she doesn’t think she’s exactly wrong to say;
“Don’t pretend like you don’t want to kiss me.”
(There’s that *‘always’* fluttering around in her head.)

Catra doesn’t do either of the things she predicted, a far better response found in her ears going down with her...embarrassment? Fluster? She thinks fluster considering *Catra* is nearly blushing and her tail is waving under the blankets again.
“If *anyone* else but you said that they’d be bleeding by now.”
She shouldn’t grin at that. “I know.”
‘And I love you for it.’

She reaches both her hands up, holding Catra’s face where it’s now shyly smiling down at her. “I have tried to stop myself thinking about kissing you for...I don’t even know how long, I

think I'm allowed."
Even though she says it, it takes Catra's obvious purr for her to actually believe herself - she can think about it. She can do a lot more than think about it. She can lean up and let Catra meet her halfway.

She slides her hands into Catra's hair. She knows Catra likes the feeling and she knows *she* liked Catra's hands in her hair last night. Catra hums, purr breaking for the moment as she does, when her fingers catch on sleep-clumped strands. She knows she couldn't have done this with the mane Catra's had her whole life, but she does miss it a little. She knows Catra does too. She'll actually be able to take care of it properly in Brightmoon if she grows it back out.

She remembers her vision; Glimmer trying to brush Catra's hair. Maybe she'll still act like she did as a child, hair a tangled representation of her wildness. Or maybe it'll remain as soft as it is right now. She kind of can't wait to find out.

She wraps her arms around Catra's shoulders, wanting to be closer to her the same as last night, and Catra does the cutest squeak when she falls to her elbows. She thinks it's payback of sorts when Catra bites at her lip. It does not feel like payback. It feels great. It has her choking down a sound she doesn't think she's never made before. Annoyingly Catra seems to know what would've happened if she hadn't kept herself in check because she can *feel* her grin against her mouth.

"Shut up."
"Didn't say anything, Princess."
She kind of absolutely loves Catra talking against her lips, like she doesn't want to part for even the second it would take her to say it. She grips whatever part of Catra is under her hands, only knowing it's thin fur over lean muscle. Catra hums again and it's strange how easily she can tell whether or not it's part of her purr.

She can feel the shift in Catra's shoulders when she puts all her weight on one arm, unsure as to why it makes her want to whine

into Catra's mouth. She doesn't, she has better control than that. Given what's just happened, maybe she should expect the hand on her side. But she doesn't because she is barely even thinking at this point (and really when has she ever been all that good at predicting what Catra's going to next?)

Catra squeezes her waist and as good as it feels, it's nothing compared to the little cut off sound Catra makes. She doesn't draw attention to it, too aware that Catra will deny or completely pull away should she do that. But she definitely wants to hear that sound again. So she kisses her harder, over and over.

Once they're too busy gasping for breath to actually keep kissing, Catra drops and curls into her side. She doesn't *want* to stop kissing but - but nothing actually because Catra's not done either. The sensation of warm lips on her jaw is still new enough to have her gasp. Which would be a lot more incriminating if she weren't already breathing as hard as she would after a race.

Catra doesn't stop with one kiss like she has before either, continuing a burning trail down her neck while her hand rests on her side. It is *ridiculously* hard to think through the sensations.
"What are you doing?" she asks when the unexpected feeling of Catra's tongue on her skin makes her shudder.
"Do you want me to stop?" Catra is completely still in her arms, steady purr cut off immediately.
She kisses Catra's ear on a whim to try and relax her, and it does, more so than she's expecting. "No, that was an actual question."
Catra relaxes sighs fondly as her tail hits her leg, "Think you can figure it out, hotshot." Catra resumes her kisses, littering them in her words, which despite loving, does make it hard for her to concentrate on what Catra's saying. "And - you were right - before - I do want to kiss you."

Another lick from Catra and she's questioning, "Have you thought about this before?"
She manages not to gasp too loudly at the fang-point just resting on her skin. Somehow the almost-feeling is worse? Better? Than the feeling of Catra biting down. Not that she knows what that

feels like in this context, or in this spot. But she's been bitten by a playful (or grouchy) Catra enough times in her life that it surely can't be that different.

Catra laughs against her, breath unbearably hot and voice just destroying her. "Adora, I've thought about kissing every inch of you at least once."
That has implications she is not really ready to handle. (It's maybe a little more than implications but she is new to fucking *all* of this.) She coughs, trying to hide behind her hand when Catra moves back to look at her with mild horror as she realises what she said.

She's quick to reassure her that she is *fine*, just surprised, she puts her hands on Catra's hips to stop her running. She can see that Catra wants to.
"I - I haven't thought about it. But not because… I want to kiss you. I can admit that, I can say that *now*. But Catra this is - this is new for me. Well not exactly, sometimes I couldn't really help it. Especially after I realised what I was feeling. I just… I didn't get to think about these things. I didn't let myself and now you're here and *you* kissed *me* and…and I finally *can* think about it. And I don't know, it's just a lot."

It works like she meant it to. Fur stops bristling, though Catra doesn't sink back down into her. "No, I - I get that. You're *you*, of course you didn't *let* yourself, don't know what else I expected."
Catra swallows, "But I did."
"'*Everyday since you were fifteen'* right?"
"I may have been exaggerating... But not by much."

Catra's ears are pinned to her head, whether through guilt or embarrassment or something else, she's not sure. Adora decides then that she won't push her any further right now. It is early and they have time to talk about these things, they don't have to do it all now. Catra's been more consistently open in the past twelve hours than she has *ever* been, they can take a break.

"You said last night that we need to decide what we're going to tell the others about the Heart, want to talk about that instead?"
Catra nods, ears coming back forwards as she moves to lie down on her side again. Adora turns over too so they're face to face.

"I'm alright with Bow and Glimmer knowing more than everyone else. They can - they're your best friends, they can know everything…" Catra doesn't even look like she believes herself as she says it.
"You don't have to say that, I don't want them to know everything either, at least not today. They don't *ever* have to know everything, as far as I'm concerned."
Catra rests their foreheads together, and she can feel the wash of her breath as she sighs, "Thank you."

She finds Catra's hand in the bedding, "So you want to do it twice - one with just them and then tell the others later?"
Catra pulls back again, squeezing her hand, "Yeah - yeah I think I'd like that better."
"We can get breakfast with Bow and Glimmer, tell them then?"
Catra nods her agreement. "How about I tell *them* and you explain it to the others - you decide what you want them to know and I won't contradict you in any way."

Even if she kind of wants to shout it; that *Catra* loves her. (Beautiful, gorgeous, brilliant, cute, smart, funny Catra. Really there aren't enough adjectives.) That Adora loves her too and she doesn't know how to not feel this way. That Catra held her in her last moments, that she reached out and brought her back, didn't let her fall this time. That they renewed and *kept* their promise to stay together.

Catra laughs though, and it makes her completely forget what she said to elicit the response. "So if I completely gloss over you coming back to life or whatever because I told you I - I love you, you won't say anything?"
Maybe they both shouldn't blush at that, but Catra looks so pretty it doesn't even matter the fool she will (continue to) make of

herself around her. Catra just said *it* again, unprompted and with only minor hesitation. And she just loves her so damn much.

She almost kisses her again before the words actually land, and she just mumbles, "I mean they'll learn someday…" as her face gets redder.
Catra tugs on their still-joined hands, "Just admit you'd tell them, idiot."
She huffs, "Fine. I'd tell them that you told me you love me. That I said it back and I saved the world because of you."
"I didn't - you keep saying that…" Catra's ears fold down but she's still blushing so she thinks it's safe to keep pushing.
"You did Catra. You saved the world. And I will tell that to everyone who will listen."
"I - shut up."

She can't help laughing since Catra says it while shuffling so she's curled up under her chin. She wraps her arms around Catra immediately, squeezing her into her chest and kissing her ear when she starts purring. It is...a lot of affection. Or maybe it just feels like it because it's *them* and they grew up in the Fright Zone. Maybe this is normal for...for whatever they are now. More than friends at least.

"Catra are we - are we girlfriends?"
She rubs at Catra's ear where she can reach it, doing it even though it distracts Catra from her question. She can hardly fault herself, the way Catra quite literally shakes herself out of it is adorable.
"Uh, yeah, yeah I think we are."
Her face hurts she's grinning so wide. "Cool."
Catra moves in her arms just enough that their eyes can meet.
"Cool?"
"Yeah that's so cool!"
"You -" Catra bursts out laughing, and Adora can swear her eyes are actually sparkling. "You fucking *dork*!"
She laughs with her because Catra has one of, maybe the most, infectious laugh she's ever heard. "Yeah, but I'm your dork though."

When Catra stops laughing, she chews on her lip. "Mine…" Catra's claws have always had an annoying ability to cut her thoughts like thread, now is no different as one drags softly down her cheek. "I can get used to that."
She's sure her face is bright red again, and she's still not breathing right both from kissing and now laughing. Catra just smirks in response, looking downright devastating before she's kissing her again quickly. Really, Catra's just not letting her recover today.
"I'm yours too. Always have been." Just...no recovery. None. "You okay there?"

It takes her a second, "Yeah, yeah I'm amazing. You're just...wow."
Catra laughs again, tucking back into her chest and honest to gods snuggling under her chin. And yet she's still a little surprised that Catra just lets her hold her for a while. It is without a doubt the laziest morning she's ever had. And the best.

It's quiet. It usually is in Brightmoon, Catra will learn that. The only sound is Catra's purr and running water, and it's so different to the Fright Zone that it has her smiling. The first proper noise that comes in through the window is too quiet for her to know what it is, but Catra's ear flicks against her neck.

"What do you hear?"
"Just people, lots of them."
"With Prime gone people are going to be coming home. I'd say fifty-fifty Glimmer's either planning recovery missions or a celebration. *If* she's up yet."
"Y'know I actually like parties..."
Her mind latches onto the image of her going to a party with Catra proudly on her arm remarkably quickly. (That, and musing the idea of a tipsy Catra getting as giggly as she does.)
"Well, the Rebellion threw enough of them during the war, and I can't imagine they'll throw *less* of them now it's over."

Catra tenses, from which part, she's not sure. And she doesn't relax even as she starts petting her ears again, though she can feel that Catra wants to. "What's wrong?"
"Nothing, I'm fine, I just - I'm going to have to leave this room."
She thinks about making a joke about it, but decides against it. It's not what Catra needs right now. Not with how apprehensive she sounds.
"But we don't have to yet, okay? Kind of feel like I'd be happy staying here forever."

Catra relaxes back into her, though not as completely as before. "You're just saying that because you're tired, dummy. You'd be punching walls in two days maximum."
Punching not climbing, annoyingly appropriate. She scoffs, not even able to retort because Catra's *right*. "Kind of forget how well you know me. But I don't know...I think I'd survive it with you."
It's a tease, one she doesn't match with tugging on Catra's ears because that will definitely get her bitten.

Catra snorts quietly against her neck and Adora hopes she won't notice the goosebumps the air has raised. "Because I'd be here to throw you around?"
"Because you'd be here for *me* to throw around."
"You say that like I've never beaten you. I can totally kick your ass."
"I know you can."
Catra nips at her neck probably just to make sure she can *feel* her smirk when she can't see it. "Damn right."

She chokes from the feeling, just a little. And she was entirely wrong earlier. It feels *very* different having Catra's teeth (briefly) in her neck rather than anywhere else. Catra just laughs.

"As much as I don't want to stop doing this, I do need to use your bathroom."
She flops onto her back as she lets Catra loose from her arms. Maybe it's been another hour, she wouldn't know. But they can't stay here forever.

Catra doesn’t get far before she’s turning back around. “Having the shower in the same room as the toilet is weird, right?”
“No, not anywhere but the Fright Zone. It is more practical. I know you hated having other people around while you showered.”
“Well there is that. And can you blame me? After the amount of times people fucked with me because I couldn’t hear properly?”

The Horde’s communal showers, separated only by flimsy dividers, were horrendous. Glimmer teases her for never being able to relax but even in the showers you had to be on guard. It’s not like there were changing cubicles...or warm water. Back then it hadn't phased her too badly because it was all she’d ever known, but she knows she could never go back to it.

“No... Thought they stopped doing that when we became senior cadets?”
“Not completely.” She rolls onto her side, propping herself up on her arm and frowning. Catra should have told her. “Hey stop looking like that. They only did it when I pissed them off.”
“Catra that could have been everyday for all I know.”
And she wouldn’t know. From age thirteen onwards they didn’t speak until they were dressed again, she’d hand Catra her towel and pull on clothes over her wet skin. She thought her own self-inflicted avoidance was because she was uncomfortable with her own body, but she knows better now.
“It wasn’t. So stop feeling guilty, or whatever.”
She sighs, “Fine. Hurry up and come back.”

She finally gets out from under the covers when the door clicks shut. She swings her legs over the side, shivering when her feet land on the cold floor. It wakes her up at least. Another quiet noise outside and she’s thinking about Etheria - one without war. Sure, she’s been walking through it the past two days, but she can’t picture it.
There will be parties. And trips to other Kingdoms for recreation as well as diplomacy. And the Princess Alliance will still be intact, but their purpose will change.

In a distant way, it's kind of how she feels about Catra. She's had this for two days, but she's still struggling to picture it. She still doesn't know how to act with her, how different it's going to be. They've changed. And they haven't. And it feels like she's caught in a whirlwind, but it's also the most natural thing in the world. And they have time to figure it out together. That's the most important part.

She's still sitting on the bed when Catra comes back out. Catra pokes a claw into her forehead when she's close enough, standing looking down at her just like old times. "You thinking about something?"
She reaches up to bring Catra's hand down, winding their fingers together, "Yeah… When - do we need rules for this - us - when we're, I don't know, around other people?"

Catra hums questioningly, "What kind of rules?"
She squeezes their hands together, "I want to know what you're okay with me doing. I know I did some things yesterday that you weren't okay with."
"It wasn't really anything you *did*, it was… You - there were other people, and you were saying things that I'm going to struggle with *alone*, so…"
"So no serious feelings talk when we're not alone?"
"Basically."

"Holding your hand, all that stuff is okay?"
Catra chews on the inside of her lip as she reaches to take Adora's other hand as well. "...Maybe - maybe not all the time. I don't know yet. But so far? Everything's been good."
"Ok that's - that's good."
"Just ask me, before you do something...new."
"Yeah, I'll - of course, I should've been doing that."
Catra huffs, "Adora it's not like we've never held hands, or slept next to each other. That stuff's not new."
She shrugs smiling at the ground, "Feels like it. So if it was okay before, it's okay now then?"
"Yeah, yeah I think so."
"Okay."

Catra moves slowly enough that she sees it coming as she disentangles their hands and sits in her lap. She doesn't even feel bad about the way she visibly lights up (maybe even literally, she can't see her own eyes.) And she welcomes it softly when Catra kisses her. It's short and doesn't lead to more and she loves it exactly the same as every other.

Catra just looks at her afterwards. Her eyes are probably glowing, mostly because she feels like She-Ra is flowing in her skin from the love she's feeling. But she won't let her out. She-Ra isn't needed right now. Catra loves *her*, not She-Ra, even if she technically is her.

Catra's not purring, but that's okay. She knows Catra is content here. Or at least she was; the way Catra changes is miniscule, but she knows she's just realised something. Catra's ears fall slightly as she asks, "Can you - can you not kiss me, in front of people?"
She can't say she's not disappointed but it's Catra, and it makes sense. "Yeah, of course. Whatever you want."
Catra loops her arms around her shoulders, "Thank you, I just…I don't know, I want that to be...ours?"
And doesn't that just soothe something possessive inside. It's reassuring. She wouldn't think it would be. "I'd like that. I still like things being *ours*. I always did."

Catra's face shifts into a smile, one that grows both wicked and loving; disorientating to say the least. And she thinks Catra's going to kiss her again (or she's just hoping she will) when something breaks the heavy air.
"Hungry?" Catra asks, looking amused.
Damn Catra's hearing. And now that she's brought it up, it's not like she can ignore it.
"...Yeah."

Catra gets off her, pulling her to stand by holding both her hands again, "Time to face the music, Princess. And that music is your two best friends, one of whom is a nosey little shit."
And she's sure Catra's going to let go before she asks, "Hey about kissing you, can I do it in front of Melog?"

Catra rolls her eyes, “That’s fine, idiot.”
“And around other people is it all kisses or just ‘proper’ ones?”

Catra snorts, calls her a dork again, and hums as she thinks it through. “Ask first. I’ll probably change my mind depending on who's around.”
Okay well now she’s got to figure out how to ask without words because she’s very sure she can’t do that in front of people if she can’t do it in her own room.

She lets go of only one of Catra’s hands, “What if I did this,” she taps twice gently on Catra’s cheek, “Where I want to kiss you? Then other people won’t know.”
Catra flushes slightly and nods. “Now go get dressed I can hear your stomach growling.”

Catra

She really does like this balcony, even if she only came out here for Adora to get dressed. She can’t see the procession of returning people, but from the sounds of it, it’s a pretty steady train. Gods she’s not looking forward to being around other people again.
She focuses instead on the sounds of Adora moving about, then Adora pulling the curtains aside and coming up behind her. And yet she still jumps a little at hands on her hips. But it’s not as if it’s a feeling she’s ever experienced outside of a fight, and never with any sort of gentleness.

“Can I…?”
She nods and moves back carefully into Adora’s chest as arms wind around her middle. It’s nice. It’s really nice. And warm and she knows Adora is smiling as she rests her chin on her shoulder. She purrs, easier than it was to do yesterday, and even curls her tail around one of Adora’s legs. She is by no way used to Adora just...touching her whenever she wants. She’s not fucking used to any of it. She’s terrified to do most of it, only soothed when Adora gives back. And she always does, apparently.

She wonders if Adora is as nervous as her, she really has no idea. Whatever Adora's feeling, she's just grateful it means she'll do this, be this, with her.

Arms squeeze her tighter for a moment when Adora realises what her tail's done, and it makes her laugh just a little. (Adora might say it's a giggle but it is *not*.)
"Always wanted to hold you like this."
"Yeah?" Adora nods, nose pressing into the short hair that curls below her ears. "...I like it."
The kiss Adora plants on her neck annoyingly makes her let out a surprised little sound that she is astounded (but grateful) that Adora doesn't comment on. Adora does it again, probably trying to get the same reaction but she's too stubborn to let it happen.

"I'm alright to leave you know, I'll be fine." She turns around in Adora's arms, not ready to be ridded of the warmth yet. "Although I just realised I don't have any clothes."
Not that she doesn't love being in Adora's clothes, but she's not going to be caught in them the day after arriving in Brightmoon. Glimmer will be a fucking menace with what happened in the Heart, sooner or later. She doesn't need to give her more ammunition.

She snickers a little at the way Adora brightens at being able to do things for her. "I'll go get them. And probably Melog."
"Yeah, you're not sneaky enough not to wake them."
Adora pouts about it but she knows that Catra witnessed every stealth exercise they ever had to do. "I was more thinking if you're awake, they're awake too…"
"Don't think that's how it works, dummy, but if they're not awake by now I'll be impressed."
Adora looks to the moons in the sky, "It's almost noon isn't it?"
She pushes at her shoulder, "Yeah, so go get my stuff so we can eat."

She follows Adora back into her room, and really it is stupid how much she doesn't want her to leave, even if only for a few minutes. They're in this timeless bubble right now; she likes it,

wants to keep it. She wants a lot of things. Some - some she can actually *do* now. And it leaves her floored for a moment before that same fear creeps back in.

"Adora, wait."
She pushes through it. She gets to have this; Adora's hands on her waist as she stretches up to kiss her, if she casts the fear aside. Her whole body feels like a live wire as Adora pulls her closer and sucks lightly on her bottom lip because of course she has to do that when they're going to leave soon. Adora's brushed her teeth now too, out of habit since they haven't eaten yet, and it does taste much better.
Really it's just one long kiss, but it's enough to have her grinning smugly when she catches Adora's dazed face. She tells her, "I can do that now," not even caring how lovestruck she sounds.

She thinks Adora's smile is because she realises that too, it's pretty much confirmed by Adora biting her own lip before kissing her again. It's quick, almost casual even though it feels anything but.
"Can we...do that again, when I get back?"
And she's *proud*. She knows that was hard for her, Adora whispered it, and she looks ashamed to have even said it at all.
"Of course. Anything you want."

She doesn't really let herself think as she waits. Not about anything other than kissing Adora at least. In a wild turn of events, that is one of the safest things she can think about. She's tracing her lips absentmindedly when Adora gets back, clothes and Melog in tow. They push into her head that they slept well as she pets their mane.

Adora looks shy when she glances up at her. Catra stands, taking the clothes from her and throwing them haphazardly on the bed somewhere behind her. She kisses Adora like she's proving her point that they can do this in front of Melog. Adora meets her eagerly, a small happy noise lost in the connection as she holds

her hips. It feels like Adora's trying to make them touch everywhere that they possibly can and she loves it. Makes her feel wanted.

She slides her hands into Adora's hair, pulling the band out and rolling it onto her wrist. Adora doesn't even seem to notice until she pulls back, looking dazed again and just so unfairly beautiful with her hair down. That is why she did it after all.
"Why -"
"You look really nice with it down," she shrugs, "Softer."

She spins away before Adora can say anything.

She grabs her clothes and gets dressed. She looks...happy in the bathroom mirror. It's strange. And it's still disorientating to see the short hair, it's not like there's been many mirrors for her to pass by since the cut. It's going to be a bitch to grow back out, but the sooner the reminder of him is gone, the better.
And with that, the reality that she's going to leave the safety of Adora's room sinks in unfairly quickly. She pats down the fur that's visibly on end in the mirror, tries not to let the tension in her jaw show too much as she opens the door.

Adora's redoing her hair in one of the three mirrors that are built into a table on the other side of the room. Adora meets her eyes in the glass and it makes her remember the amount of times this happened in the Horde locker rooms, gazes never meeting long even if the distance of reflection made it easier. But neither of them glance away now, and she wonders if this was always how Adora looked at her.

"You're doing that face."
"Which face?" Adora asks, still smiling softly. Fuck, she's gorgeous. She curls her tail around her own leg, "You know…*that* one."
Adora turns around, leaning back on the desk and asking so fucking earnestly, "What does it look like?"

She - she doesn't know if she can describe it. She can't very well say, *"Everything I've ever wanted."* So she settles for something

easier to explain.
"Like you... Like you love me." It's hard to say. Harder to breathe. There's still something inside her warning *'what if you're wrong.'* But Adora doesn't pick up on her discomfort, still fucking looking at her like she's never been anything but good.

"Well, you know the answer to that."
She does. *She does*. But it still makes her feel jittery. She can't tell whether it's good or bad. She wants to hide, but she wants to hide in Adora's neck and just breathe her in. She's sure she's blushing. She has felt the blood rising in her cheeks an uncountable amount of times already today and she's surprised she's not light-headed with it.

Melog is glowing a conflicted blue and she feels exposed. She strides up to her - her *girlfriend* to distract her from the beacon of her emotions sitting on a pile of pillows. The free-falling feeling in her chest doesn't ease because Adora's *still* looking at her like that. She wants to kiss her breathless. And she wants to tackle her to the ground because that's what she knows best.

"I - I do." She reaches up to smooth out where Adora's eyebrows are drawn together with her thumb. And of course Adora has to giggle at it, face scrunching up in a way that is absolutely too cute.
"Can I say it?"
Her heart melts a little simply because Adora is asking. But the answer is no. Not right now, not when they're about to leave the one safe place in Brightmoon. And she's going to be thrust back into reality, where she has to deal with everything she's done that all mean she shouldn't have Adora looking at her like that. Shouldn't *have* Adora at all. She'll feel horrible if she has to say that to her. She - she just...it's like Adora said earlier; it's a lot. It's too much right now.

She steps back, realising how much of her body is pressing Adora into the wood. She crosses her arms and huffs, "You do remember how many times we're gonna have to tell the whole Heart thing today?"

"That's only twice. Hopefully…" She doesn't match Adora's fond look, just stands there unsure of herself, feeling guilty for not being able to say anything. And Adora figures it out, "Is it too much?"
Well...at least she didn't have to say it. At least Adora doesn't *seem* disappointed or hurt. Although her prolonged silence is starting to change that.

"You're - you're going to have to give me time, okay? It was fine - good - earlier but now... It - It's *so much* Adora. And it doesn't feel safe to feel like that when I'm about to go out there."
She's preparing herself for rejection. She can't stop that. The vulnerability makes her want to hide, and she's uncomfortable enough that Melog comes over saying, *"It's okay. You're allowed to feel like this."*
Adora looks sadly down at Melog at her feet, "I'm sorry I didn't mean to-"
"- You didn't do anything wrong, I'm…"

'I'm wrong.'
She can't believe she has to ask Adora to *not* tell her that she loves her. There has to be something broken inside her, but she knew that.

"Catra, I'm not...disappointed or whatever you think it is that I'm feeling. It is *a lot*," Adora mirrors her words back at her and it gets her to stop frowning at least. "Remember that it's been *always* for me too. I guess...I guess we're just reacting to it differently."
"Obviously," her voice manages to break on the single word.
"I want to tell everyone that'll listen. I - it's all I ever want to say again because it's been buried so long... But I know you and - and I should've realised you'd need to get used to it..."

She's distracted by the words, how they make her feel, how wanted and just *elated*. Enough that she's just staring for a few moments, watching but not seeing the way Adora's curling in on herself. She forces her heart to snap out of its haze when the sight before her finally registers. Adora's probably thinking that

she's 'too much' or some other bullshit rooted in Shadow Weaver's training.

Why are they so bad at this? Adora's trying so hard for her and she's...she's just shutting it down now. A few hours is apparently all she can handle. She doesn't want to explain herself, she doesn't want to talk anymore. She just wants to face the world and get it over with. But she's got to think about Adora here. She can't just ignore these things anymore.

She steps forward, wraps her arms around Adora's waist and rests her head on her shoulder. She waits until arms come around her too before finding the strength to say, "Adora it's - it's okay. Everything today - you've - I've loved all of it, okay? *You're* not too much. It's just those words. It's this place and everything else."
She feels some of the tension leak out of the body in her arms, feels Adora's sigh ruffle her hair. "Okay. Okay. I believe you."
"I'll get better… I promise."

"You will," Melog meows happily at her feet.
She takes back an arm to pat them, and they hum their static trill.
"What did they say?"
"Don't worry about it. Doesn't translate all that well."

Adora knows she's lying but she doesn't say anything, just putting an arm over her shoulders. "Y'know, when I said we should have rules earlier? This is what they're for," Adora whispers in her ear, conspiringly.
She manages to laugh weakly, "Yeah, okay maybe you were right about those."
Adora squeezes her into her side, "Come on, let's go eat. I think we can avoid the Best Friend Squad for another half an hour or so."

Chapter End Notes

> Listen Catra will cry if she hears I love you too many times in a row okay she's fragile right now

Adora’s been bottling and repressing and now it’s trying to burst out while Catra’s shying away from the intense feeling because...they’re *them*.

Part II

Chapter Summary

"We talked." Might as well get this started.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora

"You look happy."

Needless to say they do not manage to avoid Glimmer and Bow for a full half an hour. It's more like ten minutes but she thinks Catra's feeling secure enough to deal with them now.

"I am happy," she says, smiling at Catra far too widely because it makes her scoff, even though she's definitely trying not to smile too. Catra's tail has been wound around her ankle since they sat down in the kitchens.
She knows Glimmer wants to ask more, she's been trying not to pry for three days, understandably that's wearing thin. It's *visible*.

"We talked." Might as well get this started.
Bow looks…proud, maybe? Glimmer starts sparkling with her excitement, "And?"
"You give me shit for the name but it's fucking accurate, Sparkles."
"You're the worst," Glmmer turns back to her with her arms crossed, "...Are you going to fucking tell us or not?"
She sighs, "Yes."
"Thank you! Fucking gods, it's about time!"
"Glim," Bow chastises weakly. She knows he wants the story as much as Glimmer does.
"Sorry, sorry but they've been…" Glimmer waves her hands at them and Catra scoffs.

“We’ll tell you,” Catra’s tail twists around her ankle tighter, “But not here.”
“Library?” Catra's ear flicks - does she even know what a library is? The Horde didn't really have one. “Swear you’ll like it.”
“Fine.”

Catra

Annoyingly Adora was right, she likes the library, and her *girlfriend* is grinning because she knew that. With the lights off, the dark is a welcome reprieve from the rest of Brightmoon. The smell of books is not one she’s used to in any respect but it’s nice.

Bow leads them over to a corner - an actual corner not just another rounded wall - with large armchairs and an unlit smooth stone fireplace. Bow and Glimmer, of course, settle into a chair together (Adora said they weren’t a couple but…) It at least gives her some courage; if they’re doing it then she can as well.

Adora looks far too elated when she crawls into her chair with her. It’s big enough that they could easily sit side by side but she is still thrilling at the amount of contact she’s *allowed* to have with her now, which means she’s definitely going to curl up under her arm so close to her they’re practically plastered together.

Adora still doesn’t expect it, even with how they were this morning. Or maybe *because* of how she was this morning. She wants Adora to touch her in front of people, she’s always been comfortable with that even when she definitely shouldn’t have been. But knowing Adora, she’s probably going to keep the contact to a minimum until she figures out boundaries. Which is sweet, but she doesn’t want to wait that long.
She purrs, inaudibly, but enough that Adora can feel it. *Now* she relaxes. (She’s kind of smug with knowing her so well.)

She doesn’t know how to start this, but this one is Adora’s turn, so she supposes she doesn’t have to. The silence isn’t exactly

uncomfortable, just stilted. And she can't help looking at the empty fireplace.
"Never sat next to a fire that wasn't for cooking or warmth or light or whatever... Or a garbage incinerator."
"Hey, we have good-ish memories with that incinerator."
She's not wrong but, "It stank."
Adora rolls her eyes, squeezing her when she shrugs. "Most of the Fright Zone did, between sweaty teenagers and sewage and smoke and no ventilation and -"
"- And you don't have my nose! Gods, I will not miss that."

Glimmer asks, sounding confused and mildly concerned, "What did you do with a garbage incinerator?"
Catra almost laughs seeing Bow grip Glimmer's hand. "I'm kind of scared to know."
"We'd use the light to make shadow shapes on the wall. We'd count how many we could make before the next person came in and we'd have to hide." She looks at Adora to say it, just because wants to. Adora was right; good-ish memories, better than a lot of them.
"Kind of surprised we only got caught four times."
"Would've been less if you didn't have that forehead of yours."
She can't even get through the sentence without laughing - Adora did actually get them caught once because the top of her head was peeking over the top of some crates. Adora's trying her best to glare but she's clearly biting the inside of her cheek trying not to laugh too.

"Alright, alright we get it you two were cute as kids even if the story is sad. Now tell us everything!"
Glimmer's voice snaps her out of whatever gravity Adora caught her up in. Bow's given up trying to stop Glimmer, evidently. And fair game to him, even she knows how determined Glimmer gets by now. She sighs, really not knowing how to prepare herself for this. Adora copies her, breathing heavily before settling down further into the cushions.

It takes Adora opening her mouth before:
"Wait, before you start, me and Glimmer have some news."

Glimmer looks about as startled as her and Adora do. "We do?"
He gives her a look. "Oh right - oh you want to do that *now*?"
"Well I don't want to do it after them. It's going to be…y'know?"
"Okay, yeah you're right. We *do* have some news. We're dating!"

Adora *sighs*, "Oh thank the gods."
It's a snap realisation, "I told you!" She hits Adora on the arm lightly, she's not serious but the way Adora huffs indignantly is worth it. "And congratulations, or whatever."
"Thanks, Horde Scum."
"How did it happen?"
She thinks if Adora weren't as tired as she is, she'd be bouncing. This was clearly a long time coming.

"Well, we teleported back to the surface after Catra and Shadow Weaver ran off to find you and I just kind of blurted it out."
Adora shifts uncomfortably at the mention of *her*, just as she herself freezes. Now is not - this isn't about her or them. She knows that. The sick feeling in her gut doesn't.
"It was sweeter than that, she's not telling it right."
She forces everything away, she's going to have to face what Weaver did twice today as it is. She is not about to make right now a third. She can focus on how softly Bow speaks, how truly besotted he looks.
"I - I just couldn't stand for everything to end without telling him. I finally worked up the courage before we had to separate."
"And I said it back. But we didn't kiss until after everything."

Catra wonders if she looked like Glimmer does this morning - if she brightened as visibly as Glimmer does right now as she realises she *can* kiss him. The Queen is almost grinning too widely for their lips to meet, but she's doing her damn best and Bow is so obviously beyond happy under the contact.

"Please never ask me to keep secrets from each of you again. I almost messed up so many times."
"We won't. We actually talked about that last night, we're surprised you lasted as long as you did." Glimmer is snickering as

Bow says it.
"I'm not that bad at lying!"

She is still too tired to argue for the sake of it. And Adora's not technically wrong - she can lie well under specific, undefined circumstances. Maybe she'll find out exactly what they are one day.
Catra knows Glimmer's about to argue for her but Bow cuts her off, "Now go on. Tell us everything. I'm ready for you to upstage us."

Theirs is…a little more dramatic. And she doesn't really want to relive the horrible prelude to their confession so soon. Adora takes one of her hands; it helps. Melog curls into a ball on the floor, nosing down into their paws. And Adora pulls her closer after seeing it, she doesn't fight it.

"Uh, alright. I...I guess I don't know where to start."
Glimmer makes an obvious show of settling down and Catra rolls her eyes at it. "From when you left us to defeating Prime. Go."
"Okay, okay, um… I guess the first thing after that was another hologram -"
"- She saw you, by the way." Catra's too busy looking at Adora for her to realise Glimmer is talking to *her*. "She probably isn't going to mention that part but - that was why you ran off right?"

Adora looks sheepish, it's cute. "…Yeah. It - I was thinking about you so it showed me some memories. Good ones…mostly. It just made me miss you more, just - can I get on with the story now?"
Adora moves the arm that's around her shoulders, petting almost subconsciously down her arm. She knew Adora's always liked the feel of her fur, she never thought it brought her comfort though.

"I saw Mara - she was the last hologram the castle gave me. She told me things and I don't - maybe it was the memory of her. Maybe it was made by my own head. Whatever it was, she was there and she made me confront some things I guess...
"I couldn't see the virus no matter what it was, I didn't realise Prime had hacked into the monster down there with me. He froze

the hologram, said some things and then attacked me, poisoned me. I got put back in reality and there was that monster in front of me and I couldn't really stand, let alone fight and… It would have killed me if Catra and - and Shadow Weaver hadn't showed up. Weaver dragged me away after…"

"After I stayed behind to save your ass." Adora glaring half-heartedly is better than the conflicted moroseness of moments before. "Oh you cannot look at me like that."
Adora looks down and she follows her gaze to where Melog is nuzzling at her foot. It makes her soften.
"Catra stayed behind and almost died fighting that thing. And you were *going to* before I managed to get Shadow Weaver off me long enough to get back to you."
Adora's looking at her again now, her grip on her hand in their laps getting tighter as she speaks. Adora is *right*, she was going to die to that thing, even if she maybe doesn't want to admit that. She has thought she was going to die so many times in her life she's lost count. This one was different and she knows it, that doesn't mean she wants to think about why.

Adora continues, "She charged herself up with the power from the Heart and I'm honestly surprised she didn't just take it for herself. She...she came back and sacrificed herself -"
"- Didn't feel like a sacrifice. Felt like one last fucking manipulation."
Why can't she keep her mouth shut when it comes to Shadow Weaver? She'd have thought she would have learned by now it only ever brings her misery. Even with the witch dead.
Adora swallows. "I know. I know and - I don't know what she was trying to accomplish by doing it. I don't know why…"
"It wasn't out of the goodness of her heart. She didn't *have* any."

Adora looks down at her knees, face a picture of conflict.
She didn't mean to say it like that, but she does mean it. She doesn't *want* it to be true and she doesn't want it to hurt. Because it does. It always does, she just always has to *feel* about it; she couldn't be blissfully numb and uncaring. And fuck, this is not the first time she's wished to feel nothing, to not care but…she feels

justified with this. She's not running away from hurt *she's* caused, she wants to flee from the pain someone else did.

She's surprised Melog's not reflecting her distress like a beacon, they're a sad empathetic ball on the floor but they're not drawing attention. They're also pointedly staying out of this, not pushing any feelings into her head other than a dull calming sensation. They're not telling her how to feel. Neither is Adora actually.

Adora's face screws up as she thinks alongside her. She can and can't imagine how Adora feels about it. Shadow Weaver *hurt* her, more than she knows - more than even Adora knows. But she wasn't hurt the same way and that's the divide that's always been between them. But with her gone she hopes more than fucking anything that the rift doesn't get bigger. There's no more pain being poured in to widen the gap with her gone.

Adora's fingertips press firmly into her skin as she stares down at their hands. "Catra I - you're right. I *know* you're right but she still died for us."
She tries to bite down on her tongue, focus on Adora agreeing with her. Adora can feel differently about this, she won't be mad about it. But she is *mad*, and hurt and angry and grieving. She's always hoped for Weaver to suddenly be better, and she never did it. She never *will* and she just has to accept that. Accepting has just never come easy to her.
"So? That doesn't - as if that bitch would die for anyone other than herself. She still died on her own fucking terms and that's more than she deserved. She had a reason, and even if we'll never know what it was, it wasn't *for us*… I just - I can't believe anything else. I'm sorry if you don't like that but -"
"- Catra. I'm not…" Adora turns her body towards her, forces her to look at her, "I - I just want to believe she was better, right at the very end. For *both* of us."

Adora's always been hopeful; maybe more than hopeful. Adora probably thought Weaver was good for...some time, it's not like they exactly had much to compare her to. Adora is...naïve and optimistic and - and even if Catra can't understand how anyone

could possibly see good in that woman, she won't let it drive her away again. No more cliff edges. No more leaving. She thinks she would've said what Adora just did when she was younger. Before Shadow Weaver broke out of her cell and abandoned her.
She's tired, and glad she's not crying over her again. Shadow Weaver never deserved any of her fucking tears, it's not her fault they fell anyway. (Though the witch would say otherwise - would blame her for her own feelings, she always did.)

"Okay. I just don't want you to wake up one day in the future and - and have that hope come crashing down when - *if* - you realise she was a piece of shit up until the end."
Adora clearly appreciates her correcting herself. She almost didn't. But Adora also clearly doesn't know what to say to that, so she lets up with the eye contact and shuffles back down into her side.

"...I take it Shadow Weaver didn't come up last night?"
Both she and Adora turn back to Bow, and Melog's ear twitches waiting for the answer since they weren't there.
"No." They wouldn't have gotten as far as they did, evidently.
"We were *happy* last night. It was about *us*, I wasn't thinking about her."
Melog's calm is working but Adora outright telling her she was happy last night makes her feel better far quicker. She drapes her tail over Adora's curled up legs at that, Melog's glow brightening at their feet.
"I might be insulted if you did, Princess."

Adora doesn't hold any of the anguish from a moment ago as she looks at her, it's suddenly all gentle half-smiles, which is strange considering the tease. A hand comes up and taps her twice on her cheek, it takes her a second to remember before she's nodding (subtly). She's glad of the rule as Adora kisses her there, she wouldn't have been able to handle it well without the warning. She remembers the *kissing* aspect to last night and purrs silently, realising why Adora just did that.

There is a, to his credit, *quiet* coo from Bow. Glimmer is grinning like anything. At least they're not tackling them to the grass this

time. (She wonders for a second if she would've had the guts to kiss Adora again if the two of them hadn't interrupted. She doesn't actually know.)

Adora ignores them, pulling away with a smile before turning her gaze to the fireplace and chewing her lip. She knows they haven't finished talking about Weaver by the moroseness that settles on Adora's brow. "I…"
She prompts gently after a minute, "What?"
"Weaver, I - I think maybe she knew she wouldn't have anything afterwards. I would want her locked up the same as Hordak, I wouldn't let her anywhere *near* you." Adora looks over to the Queen, somehow steeled and apologetic at the same time. "She shouldn't have been free in Brightmoon, Glimmer. I should have explained what she's done to us, any fucking thing would've…"
"It's not your fault. I just wanted to win and I thought she was the only way to do that."

Now that, Catra can understand. She'd watched it happen to Adora. "She does that to you."
"Except you grew out of that pretty quickly."
Regretful Adora she can handle, bitter is new. She thinks it's directed at her for a moment before realising it's just not.

She sits up, "Adora -"
"- No, I know. It's too big for us to talk about right now. But I - I should've said more to her before, when you left. I shouldn't have regrets about *not* shouting at a dead woman, should I?" Adora's got that small look on her face, the one that needs reassurance that she's not alone and not wrong.
"Oh no you definitely should. I don't want to be the only one… What did you say?"
Adora shifts, not looking at her, "I don't want to tell you, but that's just because she said horrible things about you - about us -"
"- That's what she does. Tell me, you know I can handle it."
Adora chews on her lip, thinking, "She knew, right? About how I - how *we*… I don't think she would've cared about *us* like she did if she thought it was just friendship. But she just - I was hurting so bad, and I was *scared* Catra, and she threw you leaving in my

face. Said how good it was that you'd left me, that I've always been better off without you which *isn't true* and I...I kind of told her to fuck off."

Gods she wishes she could've been there to see that. She's considering breaking their kissing rule mere hours after establishing it. She doesn't but it is *close*. She hopes Adora knows how much she wants to kiss her right now - she promises herself she will as soon as they're alone. She can settle for being as close as possible in the meantime. She ignores where Melog is nosing at Adora's ankles and climbs into her lap, forcing her girlfriend to accommodate her but Adora looks far from caring about that.

"Not word for word but…" Adora trails off as she wraps an arm around her waist.
She holds her face in both her hands, "I'm so fucking proud of you, you know that?"
Her love of taking Adora by surprise (in a good way) is still going strong. She purrs amusedly to herself as Adora blushes and hides in her shoulder, mumbling, "Think my story got a bit sidetracked."
"I think we all knew it would." Glimmer's trying for a biting tease but it falls flat, it's just fond.
She gets it. She is ridiculously fond of (in love with) the flustered, affectionate version of Adora. It's a new kind of power for her; that she can make *She-Ra* like this so easily.

"Right, right. So next...next we uh, we walked to the Heart." She removes her hands from Adora's jaw and leans back against the arm rest as Adora comes out from her hiding place. "Both of us poisoned - Catra got caught on her ankle - and the Heart was floating there above us."
"It was all rainbow-y, glow-y magical shit. Very dramatic." She keeps trying to undercut the tension, even though there isn't any right now. There *was*, at the time. And she feels it in Adora's body as she remembers.
"I told Catra to leave. She didn't listen to me. And I...I couldn't get She-Ra, I just collapsed. And I," Adora's on the brink of tears, her eyes are burning into hers like she holds the answers to everything. It's intense and it takes her breath away. "I was

wrapped up in Prime's chains, in some...green void. And I'd given up, I - there was no way out. I'd failed but you were still with me, haloed in light and reaching out, shouting for me to wake up, to live, that you loved me."

Adora's crying now and she is too. She didn't know any of this - how could she - but it's *so much*. Adora's eyes are glowing and it's the only reason she's not hiding in Adora's chest. She needs to be prepared to be in She-Ra's arms instead.
"I didn't think I could save Etheria, I just wanted to wake up so I could tell you that I did too. And I finally caught your hand and you dragged me out of that place. And there you were, somehow loving me back and kissing me. And I found She-Ra because of you, so when I say that you saved the world. I mean it."

She loves this stupid, brave, amazing woman so much. Loves that *loving her* makes her literally glow. She lets her wipe away her tears in front of people.
"They don't need a demonstration, dummy." The amount of voice breaks in one sentence is embarrassing, but so are the tear tracks in her fur.
"What? Oh." The way Adora's brow scrunches up as she wrestles down the magic is adorable.

But something about… She curls into Adora's neck as tight as she can, breathing through more tears. "I - Adora, I wasn't shouting. I was whispering to your dying body. I - I thought I'd lost you. Again. For good."
Adora's arms around her don't feel crushing, it feels undeniable. She needs that right now.
"I stayed, remember? I'm here. And I… I'm not going to say it unless you want me to. But you know what I mean."
She wants to hear it, but she also wants to *stop* crying and that won't help with that. "I do."

"Bow and Glimmer are gone...do you know when that happened?" She doesn't bother to come out of the hold. "No. Hopefully it was before I started crying."
Adora winds hand into her hair and she feels the tears give way to

the familiar aftermath of stinging in her sinuses. “You know it wasn’t.”
“Shush. Let me believe. I think they’re still in here, I can hear them.”

Adora nuzzles down into her shoulder and she finds herself wanting to purr. And she does, these aren’t miserable tears, she is happy, mostly, just overwhelmed by it and everything else.
“I should’ve told you about all that - the Heart stuff - before now, shouldn’t I?”
“Yes. But I get why you didn’t.”
Adora hums into her clothes. “It’s *a lot*. That really is our thing today, isn’t it? I’m glad you’ve got to tell it next round... Unless you want to put that off until tomorrow?”
“I - yeah. I want to get it over with but…not just yet.”

She expects Adora to tell them they should go find Bow and Glimmer, but she doesn’t. She just holds her. She’s going to take it for as long as she has it; this won’t happen everyday. Etheria is in tatters and they’ll be the ones fixing it, she can’t expect Adora to drop everything for her whenever she wants. She can *hope*, but things don’t change that quickly. She just finally *has* Adora and all these selfish wants have something to latch onto, annoyingly.

She is better than the version of her that made those wants. Adora can have other friends, she can want to be away from her, and she’ll know Adora doesn’t hate her and regret every second they’ve spent together. The, *“I never hated you,” “I want you here with me,” “I love you too,”* have all acted as an antidote for that specific insecurity, apparently. It’s nice to know.

She will learn, she will be better. Not just for Adora, but because *she* wants to be. She doesn't want power and she doesn't want to be the monster that she was when she had it. Her whole life doesn’t revolve around Adora and the fear of losing her - the anger *at* losing her - anymore. She has more. She has Melog and Entrapta and Scorpia and Bow and Glimmer and Perfuma and she is trying to, and in a lot of cases succeeding, in caring about them.

And she doesn't want to leave Adora's arms (ever again) but she should probably do that whole caring thing right now.
"We should go find them. They'll probably be worried."
Adora rubs her arm. "Sorry for making you cry."
She bites down on the instinct to deny, kisses Adora's jaw instead. It's a better thing to do and she fucking can, because they're practically alone. "Not your fault."

Practically alone... She kisses her properly, tail swaying at Adora's cute surprised noise. Her heart is suddenly pounding in her chest because she definitely should've asked first but Adora is smiling.
"What was that for?"
"For telling Weaver to fuck off because I don't know if I've ever been more attracted to you."
Why did she say that? She needs to get a fucking grip and fucking *think* before she says things. They've had their feelings out in the open for not even three fucking days! Gods, why is she still looking Adora in her face and not hiding in her neck?

Adora laughs, flushed and obviously surprised, "Oh, so that's why you crawled on top of me?" She's not uncomfortable with it then at the very least.
She *doesn't* say that she probably would've ended up in her lap anyway, thankfully.
"Duh. Now come on." She sounds about as alarmed as she feels. Melog finds around her feet as she stands and pulls Adora with her.
Adora calls out, "Bow? Glimmer? You still in here?"

The two appear back in front of them, looking a little...uncomfortable actually.
"He thought it best if we gave you two some space. You clearly didn't talk about...all that."
Understatement. "No, Sparkles, we did not."
Bow puts a hand on Adora's shoulder, "Everything good now?"
Adora looks at her like she doesn't actually know, it's sweet.
"Yeah, we're fine."
"I'm gonna show Catra some of Brightmoon. We'll tell everyone else that wants to know later."

She puts an arm around Adora's waist, wanting to hang onto her. "I - I want Scorpia here for it. She deserves to hear it from me rather than anyone else."
"Which means we don't tell anyone even if they ask?"
"Yeah, don't do that."
Glimmer pouts but nods.

"Alright, well we'll see you guys later." Adora puts an arm around her shoulders to direct her towards the door after they both wave. (And Melog gets pets from the both of them.) "Come on, I wanna show you something."

Usually it's her saying that, or it used to be. A new spot to climb to, a new nook she found, a new move she learnt. But she likes it this way too, just for the nervous but genuine smile Adora is giving her. She trusts that she'll like it even if Adora isn't so sure. She likes knowing that Melog is excited about exploring, that they would be bounding ahead if they actually knew the destination. She likes knowing she saved Adora, finally. Even if thinking about *how* makes her chest constrict with feeling. She likes knowing that Adora's as conflicted and confused about Shadow Weaver as she is.

Today is good. No matter what happens later this was *good*; she didn't shut down, didn't run, didn't lash out even if it was fucking close. Melog is feeding pride back to her and she smiles at them. And Adora; she meant it when she said she was proud of her, not just for the Shadow Weaver thing. Sure, Adora shows her feelings for the most part, but she hides just as much. She was open today - she's been *vulnerable* all day.

She leans into Adora's arm around her, not purring simply because they're out in the open. Melog does it for her, the traitor.

Chapter End Notes

Me switching the chap count from 2 to 3: oops

Part III

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora

She got lucky with the library, she knew Catra would appreciate the quiet isolation of it. So she's working with that, hoping that no one will be in the gardens when they get there. Every time she's ever been, there were at most three people if it wasn't completely empty. And with the lack of people in Brightmoon, she's hoping it will be the latter case.

She holds the far-too-grand door open for Melog who happily trots into the daylight. Catra looks not exactly wary, but certainly uncomfortable enough that Adora knows she won't want to be in an open space right now. She has a plan for that.
"Anyone out there?"
Catra leaves from under her arm to check, ears twitching as she does. "No."
She's glad she doesn't have to prompt Catra to go out. Melog goes up to her side, nuzzling up under her hand and luring her into the garden properly.

Adora walks to the wall at the edge that overlooks some of the town below, leaning back on it as Catra moves around with Melog. She laughs when Catra sneezes from the pollen and Melog relays it. Catra comes over to her after that, mildly indignant and with her nose scrunched in a way that is absolutely too cute. She watches as Melog goes running off into the foliage, then switches to Catra when she gets close enough to tap her on the shoulder. She doesn't get what she's asking for since she already has all of her attention. Catra huffs, reaching for her hips and turning her round. She'd say it's unexpected - and it is - but she's thought

that for every time Catra's initiated touching her today.
Catra wraps around her back, whispering, "My turn," in her ear like it doesn't make the skin on her neck pebble. Luckily Catra lets her recover, just holding her. She feels purring in her shoulder and not for the first time wishes she could do the same.
"You're right, this is nice."

After a while, she asks, "Feeling better?"
"Yes."
Catra turns her around again and she goes with it easily this time. The stone is cold compared to the warmth of her girlfriend at her back, but apparently Catra turned her so she could kiss her. And she is far from upset about that.

She's not sure when she wraps her arms around Catra's shoulders whether it's in response to her palms pressing into her spine or just because she feels like she needs to. They just...completely wrap around each other. And in the bright light of the moons, out in the open - it leaves her breathless. She winds a hand into Catra's hair, presses in closer, Catra pulls her in tighter too. It's that disbelief again, she thinks; they *can do this now*. Catra is letting her, Catra wants her to.
"You know you smile every time we do that?" Catra whispers when the kiss breaks.
"You do too."
Catra doesn't even deny it, just rolls her eyes and continues to hold her close. It kind of shocks her a little.

She is fully intending to kiss her again when she remembers - and sees - something that lives in this garden. The greenhouse, *her* greenhouse, is sitting upsettingly intact just around the castle wall. She meant what she said earlier; Shadow Weaver shouldn't have had it. She remembers she used to come to this garden because she could tell herself she was keeping an eye on her, even though she wanted nothing more than to forget and run away. In some ways it was another thing the witch ruined.

"What is it?"
She considers brushing it off, deflecting to keep this moment as

light as it has been. But Catra needs to know, and if she wants to leave this place she will understand.
"Shadow Weaver's garden."
Catra turns sharply, suddenly tense and glaring at the structure in the near distance. Her hands fall from Catra's shoulders, not wanting to cage her in. She does take a hand though, she kind of feels like she needs to keep a hold on her in case Catra runs. She needs her - she drops the hand again, realising. It's not fair to keep her here, with her. Not today of all days. *Everything* is new for Catra and she shouldn't be pushing or demanding for anything if she wants her to stay.

'Catra's staying. She said so. She promised.'
Luckily Catra speaks to stop her trying to figure out her own whirling mind, "I don't like it."
"Me neither."
"It's not - I don't like that Glimmer let her have it. I *don't like* that she was free here after everything she did to us... I'm glad you said something."
She won't deny that the 'us' after everything makes her feel bright. As does Catra turning back to her and taking her hand. She's staying, *she's staying*. They both are.
"She didn't know. No one did. I didn't tell them what she - I didn't think it would be fair to you… And I didn't want to relive any of it without you here."
Catra's ears soften even if her face gives nothing away. "Thank you." Still not used to it. Catra laughs quietly, "Don't have to look so shocked every time I say that."

She sighs, pulling on Catra's hand, "Let's get away from it. This isn't what I wanted to show you out here."
Catra's ears perk back up at that and she can't help smiling. Melog doesn't follow them, but she assumes they'll be able to find them easily enough - these gardens aren't that big really. The exit into the space juts out of the main building, providing areas either side, on the east side the trees and (no longer) manicured foliage create a hideaway. She leads Catra there, then lets her hand go to sit down against a tree, giving her the choice to do whatever she wants.

"I like this place. No one ever thinks to look for me here, which is weird but…"
Catra looks around and pulls a leaf off a low-lying branch for seemingly no reason before sprawling on the ground by her feet. Catra's ears are still twitching around for sounds, and the tip of her tail is swishing over her legs, but the rest of her is almost as relaxed as she was this morning.
"I like seeing you like this."
Catra's ear flicks towards her, though nothing else moves. "Like what?"
"Relaxed?"
"Could say the same thing about you."
She kicks at Catra's arm lightly. "Thought I didn't know how to relax?"
Catra hums, grinning. "That's true. I take it back."
She kicks her again, Catra swiping at her boot as she does.

This part, just lazily play-fighting with Catra, is the easiest thing she could ever do. This is what people in Brightmoon don't get. There's only so much softness she can handle at once and Catra just *gets that* in a way so few others do. Even Scorpia didn't understand.
She'll take any scrapes Catra gives her right now because they are born from affection (and stupid childishness). It's familiar and it's comforting, somehow, to shove at her and get only snickers. By the time they've dissolved properly into giggles, Catra's got her tail wrapped around her wrist. It shows more trust than anyone other than them would know. She doesn't tell her she's missed her, missed being *them*. She will though, soon. Just like she'll tell her how fucking stunning she is. How her laugh is the best sound in the world. Maybe she should write a list.

When it falls into silence she looks through the gap in the bushes to her left. "I want to go running with you, down by the forest edge. Not right now but, y'know, some other day."
Gods, they're going to have *other days*.
Catra pushes up onto her elbows. "You hate running."
She...kind of does actually. Well, she would rather do a lot of other things. She forgot that Catra's the only person who knows

that. “I don’t *hate* it. I don’t like it, there’s a difference. But it’s better outside. We can make it a tour, figure you’ll be able to keep interest if we make it a race.”
Catra rolls her eyes. “You want to race so *you* don’t get bored, don’t try to bullshit me. I know you too well.”
She fucking does. “Okay fine. Maybe I just want to do something stupid with you. And prove something in the process.”
“Prove what? That I’m faster than you?”
“You aren’t.” She is.

Catra sits up sharply, tail squeezing her wrist unconsciously. She’s not even worried despite how cold Catra’s glare is. “I could beat you in my fucking sleep. I’ll fucking prove it.”
She grins. She knows how fast she is and has always been. It’s just too fun riling her up, especially when it’s so easy.
“Oh you -” Catra looks at her like she’s ready to tackle her and then it just melts away as she rolls her eyes again. “Oh for fucks sake. You’re the worst.”
“Yeah, but you *like* me, so - Hey!” Catra unwinds her tail to knock her in the face and she bats it away.

Catra gets up and she worries she pushed it too far, but Catra just sits down next to her, leaning against the tree too. “We can run tomorrow… I want to climb up to the top of the mountain with you, bet the view’s great.”
Good to know she still likes high places. Adora had lost a fondness for them with each memory of a cliff edge, but hopefully it’ll return with Catra being just *with* her again. “You know Glimmer can just teleport us up there, right?”
“Yes, moron, I know that. I also know that both of us like climbing.”
“Don’t act like you’re not gonna wield your advantage over me.”

She grabs one of Catra’s hands, pressing a thumb gently to a blade. She should probably be scared of them, but she wasn’t in the Before and she’s not now. She has scars from these claws on her back but it doesn’t matter anymore. They’re just another part of Catra, albeit a very dangerous part. She used to mess with her claws like this when they were kids, when Catra had far less

control of them, and any marks have long since gone.
"Oh I definitely will. I'll make sure you don't fall though, how about that?"
Catra's not looking at her, but nothing suggests she's uncomfortable. Actually her tail is curled around her ankle. She traces a finger down another claw and Catra ducks her head further.
"Think I can work with that... What is it?"
"What's what?" Catra asks, even though she clearly knows.
"Is it this?" She squeezes Catra's hand tighter.
Catra growls quietly, but it's not at her. "You shouldn't be…I've hurt you with them."
"Do you want me to stop?"
"...No." It'd sound sulking if she didn't now know that this is from fluster.

"There's no one around is there?"
Catra looks like she knows exactly what she's going to do and she doesn't care at all. "No."
"Good, so I can do this."
She intends for it to just be one kiss to Catra's temple but she places another two down the side of her face when Catra starts purring immediately. She nuzzles into the side of her face, happy to finally be allowed to touch the fluff on her jaw, before leaning back and picking a hair off her lip. "I'm used to finding your fur fucking every where, but that's new."
Catra's pupils are blown out wide and it really is adorable. "That's also your own fault."
"Didn't say I minded." She absolutely doesn't.

Catra hums before swinging her leg over her hip and straddling her. She's had Catra in her lap so many times today, and after how often Catra would tackle her to the ground and sit on her back in the Horde she really should've expected this. Catra takes her hand back, retracting claws as she does. Her flash of confidence dies the next second, her ears fold down as she reaches up to hesitantly hold her face.
"I'm still trying to - are you…?"
She's sure she'll agree if Catra finishes her question, but she

doesn’t. She doesn’t really feel like she can move except for leaning into the hands holding her. It’s not enough but she’s too scared to put her hands somewhere Catra doesn’t want and risk a consequence.

Instead she prompts gently, “What?”
Catra hisses with her breath. “It’s just hard.”
“I know it is. We don’t - we have time, it’s okay.”
“I just can’t get used to this. I know it’s only been two days but…”
She’s quick to reassure her, “No I get it, I...” She takes a breath and puts her hands on Catra’s waist, loving how she fits in her hands. “I still can’t believe I get to do this now.”
It makes Catra relax a little but she doesn’t do anything but look at her.

Catra

Adora’s not scared of her. She...it means a lot. Adora is gentle with the things that have dug into her skin and made her bleed. She doesn’t understand it but she’s fucking grateful. Adora is smiling as she holds her face in her hands, knowing full well how easily she could carve her skin. It’s intense, but she thinks that only applies to her.
She wants to kiss her, and she will, but she needs to prove something first. Maybe even just to herself. She releases the claws on one hand just slightly, and drags a single one down the length of Adora’s neck, not even hard enough to leave a line. She knows she did this mere hours ago, but it held none of the weight for her then. Adora’s hands tighten and she freezes as Adora swallows.
“I’m not going to hurt you.”
“I - I know.” It’s shaky, and she doesn’t like it; she *needs* Adora to believe her.
“*I’m not*. I won’t ever hurt you again.”
“I *know*.”

She’s confused by the red on Adora’s cheeks, and by Adora pulling her into a kiss. She moves her hand to Adora’s shoulder just to be

safe. She doesn't melt into it, not with how insistent Adora is against her lips. She knows her tail snaps as Adora sucks on her bottom lip - she's still not fucking expecting it. It makes her forget the residual warnings in her head that tell her she's not safe here. She's not sure if Adora is trying to convince her that she believes her or not, but whatever the reason is for *this*, it isn't something she's going to question. It's just like before, with Adora plastering them together every way it seems she can.

It's fervent and heady and leaves her breathless in a new way. She feels kind of desperate for it and it...it's almost scary. It probably shouldn't be. But she pulls away, rests her head on Adora's shoulder while she breathes heavily into her ear. She loves that sound. (The reason for why is new, but she definitely remembers tackling Adora to the ground during training and experiencing something similar). She'd feel embarrassed of how she's clinging onto her if Adora's arms around her weren't near crushing. It takes minutes for the embrace to feel anything less than fierce.
Adora keeps her nose in her collarbone as she mumbles, "Sorry, I just - you make me feel so much."
Her purr kicks up, and she nuzzles into the woman under her. "Don't apologise."

She doesn't think Adora holds her like this for all that long, but Melog calls from a distance. She doesn't move even as they rustle the bushes coming over to them.
Adora asks them, "You bored, buddy?" Melog meows but it's not an affirmative. They just want to be around them. Adora doesn't know that. "Okay, we can do something else."
She sits back only slightly. "That's not what they mean."
"Oh. What then?"
"Just lonely, sort of."
"Oh, well then how about," Adora motions for her to turn around and she doesn't *really* want to let go of her but she does it anyway. She gets pulled back into Adora's arms, just leaning against her chest, and Melog comes and rests their head in her lap now they can.

“Oh so you’re both teaming up to get hugs outta me?”
Adora murmurs, “Maybe,” while Melog pushes a kind of smugness into her head.
She rolls Melog’s mane through her fingers, purr silent but still there. “Anyone sees this, I’ll threaten them.”
“I know you will. You’ll scare them half to death.” She loves that Adora sounds like she’s smiling saying that.
“Damn right I will.”

Adora points out her lack of clothing options when they begin wandering around Brightmoon in the late afternoon. *“We’ll get you some more clothes soon, alright?”*
“Could just wear yours.” Adora had tugged gently on her tail, she still hissed at her.
“You forget about this?”
“No. Just means you probably won’t be getting those clothes back.”

She kind of gets a tour just by them trying to find the castle tailors. There’s only one here now and they’re taking a break before getting back to work since they were chipped, so she won’t be getting anything fitted any time soon. She’s got a second outfit on Darla that she can use when Entrapta comes back from the Kingdom of Snows to collect and park the craft in Brightmoon. But until then she will be stealing Adora’s clothes when hers are being cleaned. (Adora doesn’t know that yet.)

They find Glimmer and Bow again in their wandering. She says, “You’re looking as confused as I am about what we’re meant to be doing,” after a long round of silence.
“There’s always something,” Glimmer starts, “But do we even really want to try making a list of all the things we should do? It’s just going to depress us all.”
Adora sighs, “We should. Etheria needs help. Library again or your room?”
Glimmer decides that for them, teleporting them all to what Catra assumes is her bedroom. After the dizzy spell leaves, she realises it is the embodiment of Princess-ness, complete with fluff and

sparkles.
“Aw, it suits you,” she teases.

She easily admits that the snacks brought to Glimmer’s room are amazing. It takes cake arriving and no one using cutlery for her to remember; *“We'd raid Brightmoon's kitchen for cake and then we'd eat it with our hands right off the platter.”*
“Guess you weren’t lying to me, Sparkles.”
“Told you this is what would be happening. Although I definitely think there was something waiting for you back here. Even if you didn’t know it yet.”
Glimmer looks pointedly at where she’s resting her head on Adora’s shoulder. She puts a finger up at her in response.
Adora whispers to her, “Am I meant to know what you’re talking about?” Bow looks a little concerned too.
“Nah, don’t worry.”

Melog finds a friend in Glimmer’s Kowl plushie, curling around it on the window seat. They continue to write shit down until the second moon has set. And then Adora gives her a decision to make; stay here while she goes and gets food, or brave the communal dining space again. Everyone seems surprised when she agrees to go and she rolls her eyes at all of them.
“Like the Horde cafeterias weren’t a hundred times worse.”
That makes sense to only Adora but who cares, Glimmer and Bow can figure it out.

There’s even more people than yesterday and more come over to talk to the Princesses around her. She still hates it, even with Adora sitting close enough for their arms to touch fending off most glares. She doesn’t know how to act, but they still don’t speak to her so at least she doesn’t have to figure that out right now.

She’s not really paying attention to the latest citizen, testing foods that Melog can eat. After however many years alone on Krytis with only limited vegetation, they’re happy to try new things. They’ll both see if there’s consequences for it later. Adora’s helpfully pushing everything towards her, a little too excited about

it maybe, but she's excited about every new thing she gets to show her so she's almost used to this already.
"Evening Bow, Sea Hawk, your majesty, Princesses…Commander."
"...Do you mean Catra?"
She snaps her head up at Adora saying her name, then to the citizen awkwardly trying to give her a civil goodbye. She tries her damn best not to pull a face but she probably fails. "Uh, please, it's just Catra." The please sounds like she's chewing glass even in her own ears.
At least the person looks as uncomfortable as she feels. "Oh...uh, alright. Evening, Catra."

They scurry away after that and she lets out a very genuine breath of relief. "That was horrible."
"They were nice to you. And you were nice to them. I'd say it went quite well," Bow says. He sounds so proud she's even more uncomfortable.
"How much longer do I have to be here?"
"Not much longer, if you're done we can leave now," Adora says. She's not done, annoyingly. Neither of them are ones to waste food. Her next bite is far more aggressive than the previous.

"Catra, you didn't tell me we had the same title," Glimmer tells her excitedly, and out of nowhere.
"What?"
"Well, back before…I was Queen, I was the Commander of Brightmoon's army."
She appreciates Glimmer not mentioning her mother. And in return she doesn't mention that she knows that before She-Ra Brightmoon's army was just her and a few guards.
"I was never Commander officially. That's the first time I've ever been called it, to my face at least."
"You'll probably hear it more when you make good on what you said and go to Salineas." The stiffness in Mermista's voice is earned, she knows that full fucking well. It still makes her ears press against her skull. It's not that she's even upset about the title - she likes it - it's just she's now very aware that it's come from the siege on the Kingdom.

"Great." She tears off another bite, wanting to be alone. Well, alone with Melog and Adora. "…Y'know that weapon Hordak had, for all the damage it caused, it was weak as shit."
"Huh?" Mermista looks at least more curious than she's ever seen her (which still isn't *much*, when she's used to Scorpia and Entrapta's expressions).
"Thing broke with one kick."
Glimmer, surprisingly, looks the most annoyed. "Seriously? That's embarrassing, for us too actually."
"Don't feel bad, Sparkles. He would've vapourised you if you got close."
"Like he did to you?"
Right, Sparkles is the only one to have seen her after...all that.
"Exactly. I still have burns -"

"- You do? They should've healed."
Adora's worried voice right next to her ear makes her jump, she has the decency to look sheepish. But she has a point. She hasn't really thought about the injuries, as far as she knows they are healed.
"I'm fine. I can't feel them, and I haven't even thought about them. Sure your magic worked fine."
"We're checking later."
Glimmer looks as smug and knowing as she did the other morning. "*We*?"
Nothing like what Glimmer is obviously insinuating is going to happen. Adora, hopefully, knows that, but she's still blushing like anything. It's fucking pretty. She knocks her elbow into Adora's side, "Just like old times."

Bow looks mildly distraught by that. It takes the others a second to catch up and she remembers there's no one else here from the Horde. Wound checking was a nightly affair before their teens, before she grew too insecure for it, and Adora...well she started pulling away. They both did really. She knows now it was just Shadow Weaver getting into her head, telling her to show no weaknesses. They won't *have* to check for injuries every night now, and never again. That has her feeling better than she has throughout this whole meal.

She stands up, Melog already trotting towards the door.
"We *are* having a Best Friend Squad sleepover tomorrow, right?" Bow asks, blatantly hopeful.
"Yes we are, aren't we?" Adora's not being fucking subtle.
"Sure. Only so long I can hold you off, I guess."
It's a lie, she wants to do it. She hopes he knows that. She pats his shoulder on the way out just to make sure.

She and Melog follow Adora back to her room without questioning it - she knows Adora was serious about checking for remaining burns. She thinks they're staying all night. She wants to. And Adora said she wants her here every night, but she might've changed her mind. She can't bring herself to ask, though.
Adora sits on her bed, watches Melog as they go sniffing around her room. Catra slowly comes to sit beside her, unsure how and if she should break the silence. Luckily she doesn't need to figure it out.
"So...your first *full* day in Brightmoon."
"Yeah…"
They awkwardly side-eye each other for all of a second before bursting out laughing. They are so stupid, she can admit that.

"I'm guessing today wasn't the usual?"
"No. I mean parts *can be*, but most of it was weird for me too."
Adora tugs her jacket off, which kind of confuses her when she crosses her legs still with her boots on. Sure, she always used to do that, but Brightmoon's sheets will show up any dirt a lot easier.
"You want to go into the town tomorrow? After the run."
She looks at her, suddenly very concerned, "You really think that's a good idea?"
"Yeah. If this is gonna be your home, you should see it."

This is her home now. It doesn't feel like it. (*'One day. It's only been one day.'*) She does want to explore this place, it'll make her feel safer. But the people…it's always going to be the people. She can't escape them in the town like she can here, the castle is practically empty right now. But she *has* to do this eventually. It

doesn't have to be tomorrow, but...
She doesn't know whether waiting will make people forgive easier, or whether she needs to start as soon as possible, or if trying to help will remind them of the sheer weight of her crimes and make them hate her all over again. She can't predict what these kinds of people will do and it's...it's scary. A part of her tells her that Adora won't protect her from this; from people who are right to be angry with her. She knows that's not true, she still believes it a little. Everything they say will be the truth. She'll deserve it. She's not good enough not to fight back, and she'll ruin everything even further.

"I - Adora what - what do I do?" She wants to hiss at herself for sounding so weak but she holds onto it, instead wringing out her hands.
Adora replies softly, "What do you mean?"
"The people I...I don't understand them. I don't know how to make things better. I barely even know how to do it with people I know."
"You didn't know Bow and Glimmer and they forgave you. Just say you're sorry, show that you're sorry, and they'll come around."
She sighs heavily and drops flat onto her back. "Okay. I'll try. Might need those new clothes sooner rather than later though." As if it'll make a difference.
"They're still going to be Horde colours, well dark colours. Gods know you'd hate to wear anything that might be considered pastel."
Yeah, she'll need to be in Brightmoon a lot fucking longer, maybe until the natural extinction of the world, to do that. Still, she scoffs and rolls her eyes, feeling the bed dip as Adora lies down next to her.

"It's going to be weird. It might even end badly -"
"- Wow, great pep talk. I'm so excited."
Adora whacks her gently on the arm. "Shut it, I'm not done. It *might* end badly but it *will* get better. You've got to trust that this'll get easier, people will forgive eventually even if they don't forget."
Right, this isn't the Fright Zone. It's not even the Horde. "This place is so weird. I don't have to like it."

Adora turns onto her side and reaches a hand out. “No, you don’t. But I want you to be happy here eventually.”

She takes the hand, turning too. She squeezes it before sitting up. “I’m going to go get some things from my room - fuck that’s weird to say - anyway, I’ll be right back. Okay?”
“Okay… You know what we did this morning when I got back from your room?”
She snickers quietly, feeling the memories of pressure on her lips. “Yes. I remember.”
“Can we do that again?” Adora so obviously perks up, even if she’s trying to keep herself small. As if she’s going to say no.
“I’d do it right now if I didn’t think I’d get carried away.” It’s worth voicing that out loud just to see how Adora beams. “Melog can keep you company, Princess.”
Melog jumps their front paws up onto the bed and she laughs to hide that she’s ecstatic Adora wants to kiss her so badly.

She brushes her teeth in her room, but she doesn’t bother to change there since she’ll need her clothes again in the morning. When she opens Adora’s door, she’s greeted to the sight of Melog shrunk down and rumbling happily in the well of Adora’s crossed legs.
“Having fun without me?”
“They just sat on me and now I can’t move.”
Melog meows something that roughly translates to: *“She’s warm and she gives me head scratches.”*

She drops her clothes on the floor by the bed and crawls onto it, pushing at Melog’s neck. They grumble but they know what she wants and they don’t want to be between them when it happens. They wait for her to settle into Adora’s lap before curling up against her leg. She pets their head in apology before winding her arms around Adora’s neck.
“Believe I promised you a kiss.”
Adora grins obnoxiously wide and genuine. She loves it, loves how excited she is. Loves that Adora’s already pulling her closer. “You

did.”
“Dork.”

Adora

It’s getting easier. All of this; the talking, asking Catra to kiss her, all the affection. It’s not *easy* like she’s sure it should be, but she can do it when they’re alone apparently. And she is happy to try when the reward is Catra purring against her lips and in her lap.

“I’m going to go change.”
She doesn’t want Catra to leave her arms for a second but she gets it. Changing in the same room was normal and fine, and then it just wasn’t (at least for her) but they didn’t really have a choice. She learnt to deal with the anxiety and feelings that came from being around Catra in any state of undress, she figures Catra felt the same way.

She should change too, and looks to where Catra dropped her clothes when the bathroom door closes. Yes, Catra’s wearing her clothes to sleep in, same as last night, but she switched the tops. That’s got to be on purpose, and she finds herself smiling. She probably would’ve switched the shorts too if it weren’t for her tail. Melog’s curled at the end of the bed the same way Catra used to do when she climbs under the covers, near enough to them that she can pet their head. It makes her feel a lot that she can’t even really articulate to herself.

She’s just glad when Catra comes back, watching as she stops and runs her fingers over the curtain fabric. “Hey, what do these do?”
“Oh, um, I think they’re for insulation. It gets a little cold in the winter because -”
“- Because there’s no fucking glass in the windows?”
She thought more because there aren’t incinerators burning constantly underneath the castle and everything isn’t made of heat-conducting metal but, “That doesn’t help. I don’t know why,

it’s just a thing here. You can close them though, that's what the little ties are for.”
And then it’s just Melog’s glow illuminating them.

She lights a lantern, the orange glow of it making the space around them a confusing mix of colours. She keeps the brightness low, low enough that Catra’s eyes are glowing when she turns back to her and she sits under the covers beside her. It feels safe, she thinks. Safer than anything has all day. Neither of them know what to say, it’s clear. But Catra’s petting the fur of Melog’s flank and she’s free to just take her in. She’s always going to be stunning. It was confusing when they were cadets, infuriating from the other side of the war, and now it’s just…nice. It was one of the few things she didn’t feel guilt for, really. She can think her friends are pretty and handsome, and she does. But Catra’s just always going to be different.

“Why are you looking at me like that?” Catra whispers into the space between. She can’t answer her with the complete truth; that’s she’s so shockingly beautiful it makes thinking clearly hard, she can’t say *that* yet but she will soon. She can tell her something though.
“Burns are all gone, I checked,” Catra tries when she just keeps looking at her. That’s a relief. She hadn’t forgotten about it but she wasn’t going to ask Catra if she could check herself.
“Good. But that wasn’t why I was looking.”
“Then why were you?”
She cups her cheek in her palm, “I love your eyes. Have I ever told you that?”
Catra’s tail sways behind her as she smiles, “Think you did when we were kids.”
Before she learnt to watch what she said. “Probably.”
“…I’m gonna kiss you, okay?”
She’s glad she doesn’t have to be the one to ask. “Gods yes.”

Catra’s lips are just so soft, her fur under her hand is soft, the bedsheets, all of it. She’s still not used to everything being like this, because things aren’t *like this* in their lives. But they are and maybe - maybe this is the new normal. She wouldn’t be upset if it

was. She *wants this*. She is happy and smiling and it's making this a mess and it doesn't matter because Catra's purring.
And when Catra stops kissing her, it's to say, "I like your eyes too, dummy."
The fondness is dripping from her voice and she likes her sounding like that, and likes her saying it. Turns out she wants Catra to think she's pretty too.

Catra tugs on her shoulders and she follows, keeping her hands on her waist gentle. It feels right, like it did this morning, with their legs tangled and Catra's fingers in her hair. But in changing positions, she kicks Melog and they meow an annoyed exclamation from the end of the bed.
"Sorry buddy." They mumble something as they jump off the bed and slink out through the curtain. She turns back to Catra but she's just smiling amusedly. "I feel bad."
"You gonna call them back?"
"Later -" And then Catra's dragging her back down with a hand on her jaw.

Catra

She'll apologise to Melog later too, but they can feel just how much she wants - has wanted - this. They're not even mad, just annoyed since they were comfy. They get her happy feelings through the bond anyway. She's kind of glad the empathic part of it is the most abstract. She doesn't really want Melog knowing what it's like to kiss Adora. Or anyone else for that matter. She's surprised she's still having a clear thought given everything that is happening, she doesn't want to think about anything but Adora's lips on hers. (Though being possessive of Adora's kisses isn't exactly *not* thinking about it.)

Adora tastes different than she did earlier but it's not bad. The fact she now apparently can tell when Adora tastes like she *usually does* has her purr kicking up in her throat. "What were you eating?"

She laughs quietly watching Adora's brain restart, completely unprepared to be asked anything. "Uh, strawberries? Why?"
Okay well...she wasn't prepared for further questions herself, so Adora's reaction is fair. She puts as much teasing into her response as she can, "You taste good."
There's that flush back in full force. "Thank you?"
She purrs her amusement. "I want to try something."

She's slower in bringing them back together, time allowing for a response that doesn't come. Adora lets her lick over her tongue - she likes the little sound Adora makes - and it is a new feeling, but it is good. She thinks Adora agrees given that after her initial shock, she leans down onto her further. She's breathless after a few seconds, but it doesn't feel like suffocating and she is glad because being this close to the woman she loves is amazing.

They're both panting when Adora shifts up onto her forearms enough that she can see her again. "Wait, is this okay?"
She's about to growl *obviously* and pull Adora back in, but she stops herself. Adora just needs assurance, that's all. "Yes. But what part?"
"The um, the...the me being on top of you part?"
She can't help laughing. Gods she's such an idiot, a sweet idiot that apparently can't feel her purring despite being pressed along every line of her body. "It is very okay. Why did you think it wouldn't be?"
She didn't think Adora could *get* more flushed, but she manages it, ducking her head into her chest. "Y'know you… You'd always be the one tackling *me* and you'd get angry whenever I did it, even if we weren't training and we were just messing around." Adora raises her head and her sheepishness is cute. "You - it's a power thing, isn't it? Feeling in control? I just - I guess I - please stop me talking -"

Well kissing her is her new favourite way of doing that so she just does it. "Adora, after everything that's...happened, the last few days. Can you maybe try and figure out why I reacted like that?"
"...Because you like me?"
"Yeah, yeah lets go with that."

“So...you got angry because you liked it?”
She growls to herself, hands falling from around Adora’s shoulders to the bed. She hopes her fluster at least half comes off as frustration. “I didn’t *like* that I liked it and lashed out at you, okay?”
She didn’t want to get in trouble if her feelings were obvious either, especially under Weaver’s watch.

She doesn’t want Adora to get off of her but she supposes it makes sense, at least she’s not going far, just curling up against her side. She’s careful not to trap her tail, and she purrs into her hair for it.
“Anything else like that I should know about?”
“Yes. But not today. And the power thing...I don’t feel powerless just because I’m - because I’m under you, okay?” She’s got to be blushing, but she never thought she’d ever say that out loud, and the reality of all the times they’ve kissed today is hitting her hard. She’s just imagined it so many times. Adora’s just as considerate as she would expect her to be.
“Good, good because you say the word -“
“- I know. It goes the same for you.”
She really likes Adora smiling up at her from her shoulder, she decides.

There’s shuffling from the floor and they see Melog bringing a pillow into their - what is essentially a - den. Adora, regretfully, rolls off her to reach her hand out. Melog bumps up into it as she apologises for kicking them.
“How many pets do you think I can get out of her for this?”
“Enough.”
Adora looks back at her, “Huh?”
She crosses her arms over her chest, cold even with the curtains since the body on top of hers has just left. “I’m not snitching.”
Adora huffs, then turns onto her back and drags her over. “That’s not fair. I want to know if they’re still upset with me.”
“They’re not, Princess, don’t worry. They just like you petting them.”

And then Adora starts stroking *her* head, and she's caught so off guard she chirps. She coughs trying to cover it up (and fighting against the way her purr wants to roll) while Adora's face melts into something she can't really handle.
"'Case you hadn't noticed, I'm not Melog."
"Thought you'd stopped pretending you don't like this."
She growls quietly but she's curling down into her chest and purring as she does it so she doesn't think it works as an answer the way she wants it to. It's going to take more than a few days for her to stop pretending entirely. She tries to relax into it, really does. But she's still unable to fully give herself over after a whole lifetime of denying it. She's grateful Adora doesn't say anything, just keeps the movement of her hand going.

"Are the sleepovers here like the ones we had up there?"
"Better food. More blankets. It's going to be fine if you're worried about it."
"I'm not worried. I liked the sleepovers."
Being in a group like that is nice, but it's also a lot after being mostly isolated for her whole childhood. She is used to some of what is happening right now, it gets overwhelming but it's a new kind. It's a kind she's wanted for a very long time. And it's worth it considering how falling asleep with Adora in her bed is as natural as breathing.
"I just prefer having this with you."
Adora kisses her ear and she manages to keep the sound in her throat. *New* but it's not scary.
"Don't tell them, but me too." She smiles even though Adora can't see it, winds her tail around her ankle. "Do you -" Adora breaks her sentence just to laugh, "- Do you think Bow and Glimmer are doing what we were just…?"
"Oh yeah, definitely."
"I'm happy for them. It's still weird."
"Bet it's worse for them."

Adora hums, "I don't know, I think they've been hoping for it since saving you."
Bow makes sense, well, enough sense. But she had, in Glimmer's own words, done exactly one good thing by that point. And died

for it. Sure *maybe* she liked Glimmer by that point, sort of. But she didn't really think it went the other way.
"That makes no logical sense. But it's nice having their approval I guess. I am not looking forward to telling the rest of your friends."
Adora squeezes her against her chest, "They'll like you better after. Or they should at least."
That's probably going to be aided by Adora insisting that she was the one to save the Universe, she doesn't imagine she's going to stop any time soon. Annoyingly, Adora's relentlessness is one of the many reasons she loves her. She's never really worried about people liking her before, it didn't matter if they feared or respected her instead. The new worry has been draining her energy all day and it's catching up to her now.
"It doesn't fix everything."
"It will help though."

Adora

She pulls the covers up around them, turns off the lantern, and surprisingly doesn't feel the need to fill the silence with anything. Catra's purr is almost inaudible now but it's still there. The glow of Melog's light is reminicinent enough of the Fright Zone's bunks that it calms her; really everything about right now is calming in a way she just couldn't get in Brightmoon before. She never could have guessed during the war that Melog would show up but she loves them, loves what they mean to Catra. She may not be that close with Swift Wind since he's usually away but she can still feel an abstract version of his emotions when she focuses. She thinks it's the same, probably more intimate. She wants Swift Wind and Catra to be friends, she wants him and Melog to be friends.

She's...excited. For the new life she actually has the possibility for. She doesn't have to long for Catra to be in her life anymore and it kind of feels like a boulder has been moved out the way of a stream inside her head. She wants to go running with her tomorrow, to learn all the places in Brightmoon she likes. She wants to show her the bakery in the town and introduce her to

people. She wants to walk around holding her hand and have her under her arm. She wants them to get the opportunity to be like everyone else, or as close to it as they can get.

Catra's purr stops completely, apparently she was thinking long enough that she fell asleep on top of her. The weight feels as new as it did three nights ago but she loves it. She thinks if she laid on Catra like this she might feel trapped. But she also thought she would feel uncomfortable underneath her at all and apparently she was very wrong about that. She's happy she was wrong actually, she hadn't realised that earlier. It is about the trust of it, but it's also just the feeling. So many new feelings - emotional and physical. She's been enjoying the whirlwind of them today (for the most part).

She smiles at the first of Catra's gentle snores. She should sleep too, and she knows it'll be easy like last night given everything about right now. She wonders how long they'll stay in here tomorrow. With the curtain it'll remain dark, they can stay closed off for as long as they want. Their plans for tomorrow don't coincide well with the new list they made, the one they should do since the planet still needs help. But the world is safe, people are getting help. And she doesn't feel all that bad about wanting another day with Catra and their friends after all they've been through. That's new. She's glad, guilt would mean she wouldn't be able to sleep right now.

For the fourth night in a row, she falls asleep calm with the knowledge there is nothing she *has* to do. The world is safe, she's safe, *Catra's* safe. And she has a choice now.

Chapter End Notes

This was so self indulgent holy shit.
And I'm sorry it took so long, got caught up in the killing eve au (❁´◡`❁)

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